

is the us public polarized on energy sources?

While the US is politically divided, **there is broad support for renewables and more focused polarization around fossil fuels and climate-linked policies.**

Is the US public polarized on energy sources? N = 12

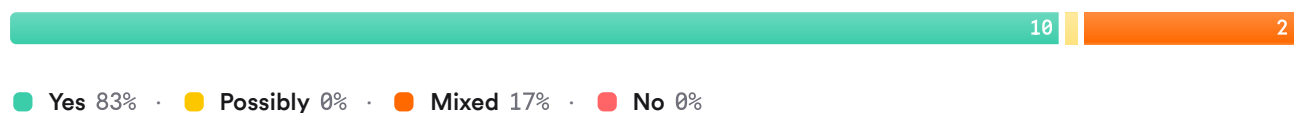


FIGURE 1 Visual summary of yes/no evidence on polarization

Public views on energy span both shared support and sharp partisan divides. The pattern depends on *which* energy sources and *whether climate or costs are emphasized*.

Overall Support vs. Polarization

- Large majorities favor **increased use of renewable energy** (especially wind and solar) and reduced reliance on coal and, to a lesser extent, other fossil fuels (■ Bergquist et al., 2020; ■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; ■ Hamilton et al., 2019; ■ Hazboun & Boudet, 2020; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; Greenberg, 2009).
- Support for renewables is **broad and temporally stable**, and generally **less polarized** than views on climate change itself (■ Bergquist et al., 2020; Hazboun et al., 2020; ■ Hamilton et al., 2019; Hamilton et al., 2018).

Differences by Energy Source

Energy type / issue	Typical pattern in US opinion	Citations
Renewables (wind, solar, etc.)	High support; some partisan gaps but still majorities in both parties	(■ Bergquist et al., 2020; ■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; Hazboun et al., 2020; ■ Hamilton et al., 2019; ■ Hazboun & Boudet, 2020; Hamilton et al., 2018; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; Greenberg, 2009; ■ Gustafson et al., 2020)
Coal, oil, fracking, drilling	Strong partisan divides; conservatives more supportive, liberals more opposed	(■ Bergquist et al., 2020; ■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; ■ Mourão et al., 2024; ■ Wolters et al., 2020; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; Greenberg, 2009; ■ Ceccoli, 2018; Mistur, 2017)
Natural gas	Lower support than renewables, mixed and less clearly polarized	(■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; ■ Hazboun & Boudet, 2020; Greenberg, 2009; Mistur, 2017)

Energy type / issue	Typical pattern in US opinion	Citations
Nuclear	Opinions split, with concerns over risk; not purely partisan	(■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; ■ Hazboun & Boudet, 2020; Greenberg, 2009; ■ Kwon et al., 2024; Mistur, 2017)

FIGURE 2 How polarization varies by energy type

Role of Partisanship and Climate Beliefs

- **Partisanship is the strongest predictor** of energy policy preferences; divides between Democrats and Republicans on energy policy have increased over time (■ Bergquist et al., 2020; ■ Mourão et al., 2024; ■ Wolters et al., 2020; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; ■ Ceccoli, 2018).
- Conservatives favor fossil fuels and are less favorable to renewables; liberals show the opposite pattern (■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; ■ Mourão et al., 2024; ■ Hamilton et al., 2019; ■ Hazboun & Boudet, 2020; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; ■ Ceccoli, 2018; ■ Gromet et al., 2013).
- Acceptance of the **scientific consensus on climate change** is tightly linked to support for phasing out fossil fuels and expanding renewables, especially among conservative Republicans and liberal Democrats (■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; Hazboun et al., 2020; ■ Hamilton et al., 2019; Hamilton et al., 2018; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; ■ Gromet et al., 2013).

Areas of Cross-Cutting Agreement

- Even among Republicans, **majorities still support renewables**, though at lower levels than Democrats; disagreements are larger over *how fast* to move away from fossil fuels and *why* to support renewables (economy vs. climate) (■ Hawes & Nowlin, 2022; Hazboun et al., 2020; ■ Hazboun & Boudet, 2020; ■ Bedle et al., 2023; ■ Gustafson et al., 2020).
- When explicit economic costs are highlighted, support drops for both Democrats and Republicans by similar amounts (■ Bergquist et al., 2020).

Conclusion

The US public is not simply split into pro- and anti-renewable camps. There is wide, cross-party support for renewable energy, but **strong polarization over fossil fuels, climate change, and some specific technologies and policies**, driven mainly by partisan identity and climate beliefs.

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at <https://consensus.app>. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

References

- Bedle, H., Garneau, C., & Vera-Arroyo, A. (2023). Clustering energy support beliefs to reveal unique sub-populations using self-organizing maps. *Heliyon*, 9. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2023.e18351>
- Bergquist, P., Konisky, D., & Kotcher, J. (2020). Energy policy and public opinion: patterns, trends and future directions. *Progress in Energy*, 2. <https://doi.org/10.1088/2516-1083/ab9592>
- Ceccoli, S. (2018). Explaining Attitudes Toward U.S. Energy Extraction: Offshore Drilling, the Keystone XL Pipeline, and Hydraulic Fracturing. *Social Science Quarterly*, 99, 644-664. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ssqu.12447>

- Greenberg, M. (2009). Energy sources, public policy, and public preferences: Analysis of US national and site-specific data. *Energy Policy*, 37, 3242-3249. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enpol.2009.04.020>
- Gromet, D., Kunreuther, H., & Larrick, R. (2013). Political ideology affects energy-efficiency attitudes and choices. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 110, 9314 - 9319. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1218453110>
- Gustafson, A., Goldberg, M., Kotcher, J., Rosenthal, S., Maibach, E., Ballew, M., & Leiserowitz, A. (2020). Republicans and Democrats differ in why they support renewable energy. *Energy Policy*, 141, 111448. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enpol.2020.111448>
- Hamilton, L., Hartter, J., & Bell, E. (2019). Generation gaps in US public opinion on renewable energy and climate change. *PLoS ONE*, 14. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0217608>
- Hamilton, L., Bell, E., Hartter, J., & Salerno, J. (2018). A change in the wind? US public views on renewable energy and climate compared. *Energy, Sustainability and Society*, 8. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s13705-018-0152-5>
- Hawes, R., & Nowlin, M. (2022). Climate science or politics? Disentangling the roles of citizen beliefs and support for energy in the United States. *Energy Research & Social Science*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.erss.2021.102419>
- Hazboun, S., & Boudet, H. (2020). Public Preferences in a Shifting Energy Future: Comparing Public Views of Eight Energy Sources in North America's Pacific Northwest. *Energies*. <https://doi.org/10.3390/en13081940>
- Hazboun, S., Howe, P., Coppock, D., & Givens, J. (2020). The politics of decarbonization: Examining conservative partisanship and differential support for climate change science and renewable energy in Utah. *Energy research and social science*, 70, 101769. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.erss.2020.101769>
- Kwon, O., Vu, K., Bhargava, N., Radaideh, M., Cooper, J., Joynt, V., & Radaideh, M. (2024). Sentiment analysis of the United States public support of nuclear power on social media using large language models. *Renewable and Sustainable Energy Reviews*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.rser.2024.114570>
- Mistur, E. (2017). Health and energy preferences: Rethinking the social acceptance of energy systems in the United States. *Energy research and social science*, 34, 184-190. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.erss.2017.07.009>
- Mourão, R., Mayer, A., Johansen, I., Bortoleto, A., Ramos, K., Brown, E., McCright, A., Lopez, M., & Moran, E. (2024). News Consumption, Partisanship, and Energy Preferences in Brazil and the United States. *Environmental Communication*, 19, 412 - 431. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17524032.2024.2419635>
- Wolters, E., Steel, B., & Warner, R. (2020). Ideology and Value Determinants of Public Support for Energy Policies in the U.S.: A Focus on Western States. *Energies*. <https://doi.org/10.3390/en13081890>